STIVEN CATALYST

SEPTEMBER 2026

MANAGEMENT REVIEW

Management without theatre.



THE MANAGER IN THE AGE OF AI

How work is being redesigned, and what leaders must keep human.

INSIDE

05 Management trends 2026

07 The numbers

08 Who decides what?

17 A KPI is a signal, not a conclusion.

19 The 15-minute operations review

STIVENCATALYST.COM

FROM THE EDITOR

Clear ideas for better management.

This edition is built on data, practical tools and clear thinking about management.

There are no invented statistics and no empty jargon, and every idea has to lead to a concrete action.

The aim is simple: to help managers, teams and organisations make better decisions and build stronger processes.

The edition has three parts: the big picture, managers under pressure, and practice you can start on Monday.

Stiven Janaqi

EDITOR · STIVEN CATALYST

Management without theatre.

SEPTEMBER 2026

Contents

I · THE BIG PICTURE

04 The manager in the age of AI
05 Management trends 2026
06 Operating models over prompts
07 The numbers
08 Who decides what?
09 AI ROI is a work design problem.
10 Productivity rises. Skills move faster.
11 The 65% culture reset

II · MANAGERS UNDER PRESSURE

12 The manager engagement squeeze
13 Promotion is not preparation.
14 How many direct reports are too many?
15 The visibility trap
16 From operations to management: the pressure changes shape.

III · PRACTICE

17 A KPI is a signal, not a conclusion.
18 Pareto before 5 Why
19 The 15-minute operations review
20 Handover is organisational memory.
21 A good SOP is not a document.
22 The first 90 days
23 One problem. Four weeks.
24 Five principles for better operations

SOURCES

25 Sources and method

COVER STORY

The manager in the age of AI

How work is being redesigned, and what leaders must keep human.



AI is changing the tools we work with, and with them how work is divided, how results are measured and how decisions are made. The new manager asks two questions: what can be automated, and what must stay human.

01

Automate tasks, not accountability

Let AI remove repetitive work, but keep people accountable for results, ethics and impact.

02

Redesign how work flows

Rethink how work moves between people, AI and processes. A new task list is not enough.

03

Keep judgment, trust and context human

Use AI for speed and scale, but keep judgment, trust and context in the hard decisions.

“A great manager designs the boundary between human judgment and machine speed.”

TRENDS

Management trends 2026

Five movements shaping the manager's work.

01 **Agentic AI enters workflows**
AI is moving from individual help to running multi-step workflows.

02 **Middle management is being redefined**
The role is shifting from administrative coordination to judgment, coaching and prioritisation.

03 **Skills beat job descriptions**
Companies look for adaptability and transferable skills, not only titles.

04 **Productivity pressure is rising**
More data and more visibility raise the pressure on managers.

05 **Culture becomes an AI issue**
How people work together is becoming part of the return on AI.

What should a leader do?

1. Clarify how decisions are made.
2. Turn trends into work standards.
3. Watch the impact on people, not only the output.

Editorial synthesis of the sources in this edition.

WORK DESIGN

Operating models over prompts

Why management changes through how work is organised more than through prompts.

AI can speed up a task. The real value appears when the organisation reviews the process, the decision-making, the standards and how the result is repeated.

01

From personal productivity to process redesign

From individual time saved to a simpler core process.

02

From faster output to clearer decision rights

Speed is not enough. It must be clear who decides, when and on what basis.

03

From isolated use to team-wide standards

Value grows when individual use becomes a shared way of working.

04

From experimentation to repeatable workflow

From scattered trials to processes that are measurable, repeatable and stable.

THE KEY QUESTION

Beyond what AI can do: how does the way the team works change?

AT A GLANCE

The numbers

Data. Context. A clearer path forward.

66%
of AI users say AI gives them more time for high-value work.
MICROSOFT

58%
say AI helps them produce work they could not have done a year ago.
MICROSOFT

40%
higher productivity growth in the companies most exposed to AI.
PWC

85%
of leaders say building adaptability is critical.
DELOITTE

7%
say they are leading in helping their workforce grow and adapt.
DELOITTE

65%
of organisations believe their culture needs significant change because of AI.
DELOITTE

FOR THE MANAGER

AI is bringing change either way. What matters is whether the organisation turns that change into a standard.

Source: Microsoft WorkLab, 2026 Work Trend Index: Agents, human agency, and the opportunity for every organization; PwC, 2026 Global AI Jobs Barometer; Deloitte, 2026 Global Human Capital Trends

HUMAN × MACHINE

Who decides what?

A good manager does not delegate blindly to AI. They design the boundary between machine speed and human judgment.

Best for AI	Must stay human
Summarising large volumes of information	Setting priorities
First drafts and documentation	Coaching people
Pattern spotting	Judgment under ambiguity
Anomaly alerts	Ethical trade-offs
Scenario generation	Exception handling

16% of AI users in Microsoft's research are "Frontier Professionals": they use agents for multi-step work, redesign how they work and share AI standards with their teams.

A QUESTION FOR THE MANAGER

Are we using AI to remove low-value work, or to remove the thinking too?

"The manager's job is to decide who decides."

Source: Microsoft WorkLab, 2026 Work Trend Index: Agents, human agency, and the opportunity for every organization

WORK DESIGN

AI ROI is a work design problem.

Technology arrives fast. The rules for how people and machines work together often lag behind.

6%

of leaders say they are making progress in designing how people and AI work together.

60%

of leaders use AI to support decisions, yet only 5% say they manage AI-based decisions well.

Role
Who does what?

Rights
Who decides?

Checks
Who verifies?

Escalation
When is a person needed?

THE OPERATING MODEL TEST

If AI delivers output faster but nobody knows who decides, who checks and who is accountable, the organisation has gained speed and nothing more.

Source: Deloitte, 2026 Global Human Capital Trends

AI AND JOBS

Productivity rises. Skills move faster.

AI is changing the output, and with it what roles are made of.

40%
higher productivity growth in the companies most exposed to AI than in the least exposed.

2×
Skills in the most AI-exposed jobs are changing more than twice as fast.

7×
In the US, AI-exposed junior roles are seven times more likely to ask for skills that used to be senior, such as leadership.

2.5×
The most AI-exposed jobs are adding tasks that rely on empathy, judgment and creativity 2.5 times faster.

WHAT IT MEANS FOR MANAGERS

Removing tasks is only half the work. Redesign how people grow, learn and take on bigger responsibilities.

Source: PwC, 2026 Global AI Jobs Barometer

CULTURE

The 65% culture reset

Most organisations in Deloitte's study believe their culture needs to change significantly because of AI.

Trust
Can the AI's output be challenged?

Transparency
Does the team know when AI is being used?

Learning
Is there room to learn without shame?

Accountability
Does responsibility stay clear?

CULTURE IS AN OPERATING SYSTEM

When technology changes faster than the team's norms, people start to improvise. That is where shadow AI, distrust and double standards are born.

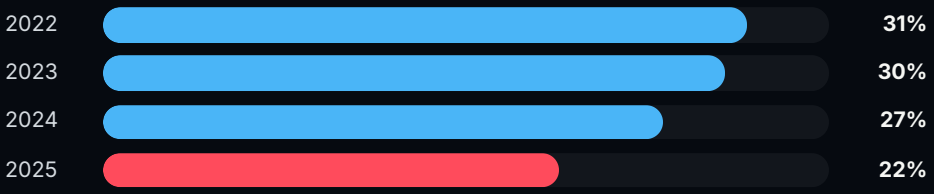
Source: Deloitte, 2026 Global Human Capital Trends

PEOPLE AND PERFORMANCE

The manager engagement squeeze

Managers used to have an engagement advantage. In 2025 it almost disappeared.

ENGAGED MANAGERS WORLDWIDE



20%
of employees worldwide were engaged in 2025.

79%
of managers were engaged in Gallup's best-practice organisations.

WHY IT MATTERS

When the manager loses energy, so does the capacity for coaching, feedback, priorities and connection with the team. What looks like a personal problem is an operational one too.

Source: Gallup, State of the Global Workplace 2026

FRONTLINE MANAGEMENT

Promotion is not preparation.

Being good at operational work does not automatically prepare you to lead people.

US FRONTLINE SUPERVISORS AND SUPERVISOR TRAINING



45%
trained in the past year

32%
trained, but not in the past year

23%
never trained

SUPERVISORS TRAINED IN THE PAST YEAR ARE

79%
more likely to be engaged

19%
less likely to feel burned out very often or always

11%
less likely to be actively looking or watching for a new job

ONE PRACTICAL MOVE

Build onboarding for new managers that covers prioritising, feedback, coaching, delegation and escalation. Do not let them learn the role only by burning out in it.

Source: Gallup, When Good Frontline Workers Make Bad Supervisors

SPAN OF CONTROL

How many direct reports are too many?

There is no universal number. But there is a practical limit: how many people can you lead without losing coaching, feedback and clarity?

MANAGER ENGAGEMENT BY TEAM SIZE

5–6
median team size per manager

DIRECT REPORTS	OWN WORK ≤ 40%	OWN WORK > 40%
1–4	37%	36%
5–9	37%	35%
10–24	37%	34%
25+	37%	32%

"Own work": the share of time the manager still spends on individual contributor work.

THE PLAYER-COACH PROBLEM

97% of US managers in Gallup's study also carry individual work, at a median of 40% of their time. When that load stays high and the team grows, management weakens.

Source: Gallup, Span of Control: What's the Optimal Team Size for Managers?

TRUST AND VISIBILITY

The visibility trap

When physical presence becomes a performance signal, management risks measuring what is seen, not what is valuable.

76%

of employees surveyed see leadership visibility and oversight as the top reason for return-to-office policies.

48%

have taken part in, or plan to try, "billboard days": office days chosen to be seen by senior leaders or clients.

87%

say a supportive manager is a top factor in how they feel about their job.

MANAGEMENT WITHOUT THEATRE

Management should not reward visibility over contribution. Clear output, collaboration, trust and results are stronger signals than simply being seen.

Source: Owl Labs, State of Hybrid Work 2026: survey of 2,000 full-time knowledge workers in the US.

FROM THE FLOOR

From operations to management: the pressure changes shape.

4	8	~250
Shift Leaders	dispatchers	drivers, indirectly

When I moved from Team Leader On Road to Area Manager after about five months, the responsibility grew quickly. My direct structure was four Shift Leaders and eight dispatchers, and the operation included around 250 drivers indirectly.

The energy did not go into one problem. It went into constantly switching between KPIs, delays, quality, damage, loading, safety and people who needed a decision or support.

What would have helped me most is onboarding made for the step from operator to manager: prioritising, delegating, feedback and clear limits to the role.

WHAT IT TAUGHT ME

A manager who reacts to everything quickly becomes part of the problem. A manager who tells the signal from the noise can start building a system.

STIVEN JANAQI

More in the essay Leading people without losing the person

TOOL OF THE MONTH

A KPI is a signal, not a conclusion.

A red KPI starts an investigation. Whether the process should change is decided later.

1. **Segment**
   Split the problem by shift, zone, category, channel or team.
2. **Find the concentration**
   Find where most of the loss collects.
3. **Go to the process**
   Look at the operational reality and check what is happening.
4. **Ask why**
   Only now use 5 Why or another cause analysis.
5. **Countermeasure**
   Try one small change and measure the result.

“A KPI does not give you the answer. It shows you where to start asking questions.”

Don't fight the symptom. Find the pattern.

Open the tool: KPI Diagnostic stivencatalyst.com/tools/kpi-diagnostic/

OPERATIONS LAB

Pareto before 5 Why

Do not look for the root cause of a problem you have not located yet.

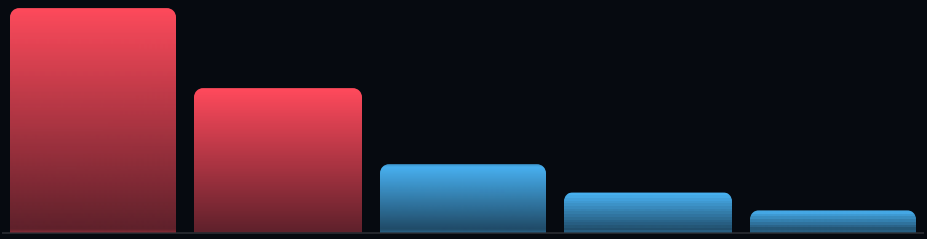


Illustration: cases by category

1. **Pareto finds the concentration.**
   Which category, zone or visible cause is producing most of the cases?

2. **Gemba checks reality.**
   What looks true in the report has to be seen in the process.

3. **5 Why looks for the cause.**
   Only once you have chosen the right problem, ask why it happened.

RULE OF THUMB

Go from wide to narrow: KPI, segment, Pareto, process, 5 Why, countermeasure.

More in the essay — Pareto and 5 Why in practice, not in PowerPoint

Open the tool: Pareto 80/20 — stivencatalyst.com/tools/pareto/

PRACTICE

The 15-minute operations review

A simple frame for reading the operation without getting lost in the noise.

1. **People**
   Who needs support, clarity or feedback?
2. **Process**
   Where is the flow of work breaking?
3. **Performance**
   Which numbers are drifting from the standard?
4. **Problems**
   Which issues keep coming back?
5. **Priorities**
   What must be followed up today, not tomorrow?

KEEP IN MIND

The aim is to see the operation more clearly. Reporting more is a different aim.

OPERATING DISCIPLINE

Handover is organisational memory.

A shift can do perfect work. The organisation still fails if the information does not reach the next shift.

1. **State**
   What is the situation now?
2. **Open points**
   What is not closed?
3. **Owner**
   Who takes it on?
4. **Deadline**
   When must it be acted on?
5. **Context**
   What must be understood, not just read?

THE TEST

If the next person has to rebuild the story from scratch, the handover has not worked.

More in the essay — Why the shift handover is one of the most underrated processes

Open the tool: Shift Handover — stivencatalyst.com/tools/shift-handover/

STANDARD WORK

A good SOP is not a document.

It is a way of working that someone else can use under pressure and reach the same result.

01
Find
The information must be where the employee expects it.

02
Follow
The order must be clear, not open to interpretation.

03
Verify
A step counts as done when the result is right; a click proves nothing.

04
Update
When the process changes, the standard must change with it.

THE STIVEN CATALYST RULE

If the SOP looks good as a PDF but nobody uses it on shift, it is documentation, and the standard is still missing.

More in the essay A good SOP is not a document

NEW IN THE ROLE

The first 90 days

In a new operation, the first job is to understand what needs to change. Showing how fast you can change things is not the point.

Days 1–30 — **Understand**

The team, the process, the KPIs, the customer, the handover, the dependencies and the problems that have become "normal".

Days 31–60 — **Prioritise**

Separate symptoms from real problems. Choose a few priorities and give each an owner.

Days 61–90 — **Standardise**

Turn improvements into a working rhythm: review, standard, measurement, feedback and follow-up.

THE GOAL

To build an operation that understands itself better and learns faster. Proving you are smart is beside the point.

More in the essay — The Operations Manager I want to be

A 30-DAY CHALLENGE

One problem. Four weeks.

Pick a problem that keeps coming back: one you see often, that costs time or energy and is worth understanding better, even if it is not the biggest in theory. Treat it as an experiment rather than a crisis.

Week 1

Observe and log

Log every repeat by category, not by culprit. Do not propose solutions yet.

Week 2

Segment

Use Pareto. Find where the cases pile up and choose the main category.

Week 3

Diagnose

Go to the process. Use 5 Why only on the chosen problem, until you find a cause deeper than the symptom.

Week 4

Test

Try one small countermeasure. Measure, see whether the pattern changes, and decide whether it should become the standard.

AT THE END OF THE MONTH

Do not try to solve everything. Understanding one recurring problem better is enough.

“One month. One recurring problem. One better standard.”

THE STIVEN CATALYST PLAYBOOK

Five principles for better operations

01 **People**
Pressure can be fair. Humiliation cannot.

02 **Standards**
If the result depends on having the right person on shift, you do not have a standard yet.

03 **Data**
The KPI is the signal. The floor tells you what it means.

04 **Ownership**
A problem must not be left without an owner, but it must not cross the limits of authority either.

05 **Continuous improvement**
Not only how we solved it, but what we change so that it does not come back.

“Leadership is not being the person who saves the operation. It is building an operation that needs less saving.”

SOURCES AND METHOD

No invented stats. No empty jargon.

Every number in this edition is tied to an identifiable source. The data is there to build the argument, not as decoration.

2026 Work Trend Index: Agents, human agency, and the opportunity for every organization
Microsoft WorkLab
https://www.microsoft.com/en-us/worklab/work-trend-index/agents-human-agency-and-the-opportunity-for-every-organization

2026 Global Human Capital Trends
Deloitte
https://www.deloitte.com/us/en/insights/topics/talent/human-capital-trends.html

2026 Global AI Jobs Barometer
PwC
https://www.pwc.com/gx/en/issues/artificial-intelligence/job-barometer/2026.html

State of the Global Workplace 2026
Gallup
https://www.gallup.com/workplace/349484/state-of-the-global-workplace.aspx

When Good Frontline Workers Make Bad Supervisors
Gallup, 2026
https://www.gallup.com/workplace/700163/when-good-frontline-workers-make-bad-supervisors.aspx

Span of Control: What's the Optimal Team Size for Managers?
Gallup, 2026
https://www.gallup.com/workplace/700718/span-control-optimal-team-size-managers.aspx

State of Hybrid Work 2026
Owl Labs
https://resources.owllabs.com/blog/2026-state-of-hybrid-work

EDITORIAL METHOD

The sources were checked for year, publisher and the exact meaning of each metric. Where an idea is editorial interpretation, it is kept clearly apart from the statistics. Personal experience is used only where it is documented from real work.

CORRECTION · 14 OCTOBER 2026

Three figures now say they come from US samples: PwC's finding on AI-exposed junior roles, and Gallup's figures on frontline supervisors and on managers who also carry individual work. The edition first gave them without the country.



MANAGEMENT REVIEW

Management without theatre.

Every month, the conversation goes on in

FROM THE FLOOR

the monthly magazine of Stiven Catalyst.

stivencatalyst.com/publications.html